

Progressive aspect is acquired before perfect aspect

Background. Structure-building approaches to child language acquisition¹⁻³ posit a correlation between syntactic functional projections and acquisition order. Two approaches^{2,3} assume generative models of adult syntax and predict a fine-grained acquisition sequence from the bottom up. However, a recent analysis of Hebrew data^{3,4} does not support distinct stages for vP- and IP-structure acquisition. Motivated by the established finding that the *be*-progressive (e.g., *they are eating*) construction is hierarchically lower (vP) than the *have*-perfect (e.g., *they have eaten*) construction (IP),⁵⁻⁷ we test whether progressive is acquired before perfect using longitudinal English production data. Though much work exists on aspect acquisition,^{8-11(a.o.)} and it is widely assumed that progressive *-ing* is acquired early, to our knowledge progressive and perfect have not been directly compared.

Hypotheses. (H1) Children's first progressive uses occur before (earlier age; lower MLU) perfect. (H2) Progressive utterance counts are initially higher than perfect. (H3) Frequency of progressive versus perfect use in toddler speech differs from adult speech.

Methods. 35 children participated in six parent-child play sessions (Visits 1-6), each four months apart (ages 19-45mos).¹² Play sessions were transcribed and adult-like utterances containing progressive and perfect (including a subject, auxiliary, and participle) were extracted. **The number of adult-like progressive utterances (n=537) dwarfed perfect (n=4), and progressive unambiguously preceded perfect at the group (Fig. 1a) and individual level.** We therefore extracted both adult- and nonadult-like progressive (n=947) and perfect (n=251) utterances (Fig. 1b) for analysis. Nonadult-like utterances minimally included a participle (*jumping*; *popped*) or subject and participle (*he biting*; *it popped*); we note these cannot always be distinguished from gerunds or past tense. We excluded unambiguous past tense (e.g., *went*), small clauses (e.g., *keep going*), possessive (*have*) *got*, and overregularizations (e.g., *knockeded*).

Results. (H1) Linear mixed effects models revealed that progressive predicts lower MLU-at-First-Use and earlier Age-of-First-Use than perfect ($ps < .001$; Fig. 2). (H2) A model predicting utterance counts revealed significant effects of structure (progressive > perfect) and MLU (as MLU increases, count increases). A significant structure-MLU interaction indicates a sharper increase in progressive than perfect utterances as MLU increases (Fig. 3). (H3) While adult-like progressive utterances are ~1.73 times as frequent as perfect utterances in adult conversational American English,¹³ in our sample of child speech, they are 134.25 (537:4) times as frequent.

Discussion. Our results indicate that children produce adult- and nonadult-like progressive aspect before perfect, and that progressive is used substantially more than perfect between 19-45mos. These results are consistent with structure-building proposals that distinguish between vP- and IP-structure acquisition stages.² The ratio of adult-like progressive to perfect utterances in our sample differs from that of adult production, suggesting these patterns reflect a developmental stage. Child speech will be compared against child-directed speech from the same sample (transcription ongoing) to assess whether results reflect a structural or input-driven phenomenon. Next, we will determine whether individuals in our sample reflect the group-level pattern and also compare our identified progressive acquisition anchor point to acquisition of other structures in this sample (e.g., subjects, hierarchically lower; tense, hierarchically higher).

Fig 1. *Progressive and perfect utterance counts across visit*

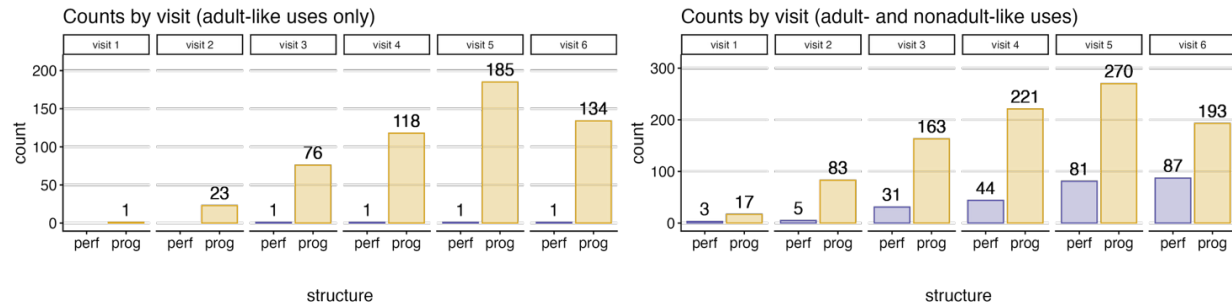


Fig 2. *Progressive predicts lower MLU-at-First-Use and earlier Age-of-First-Use than perfect*

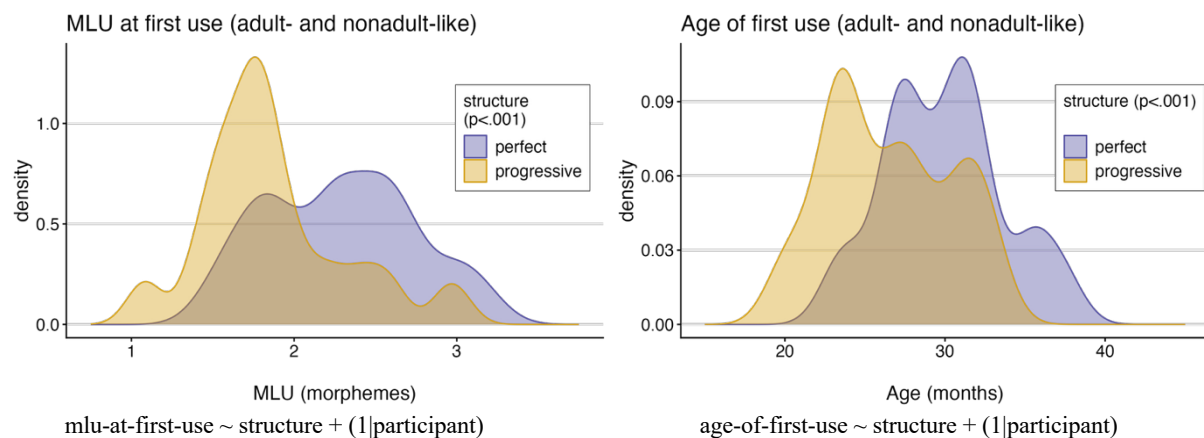
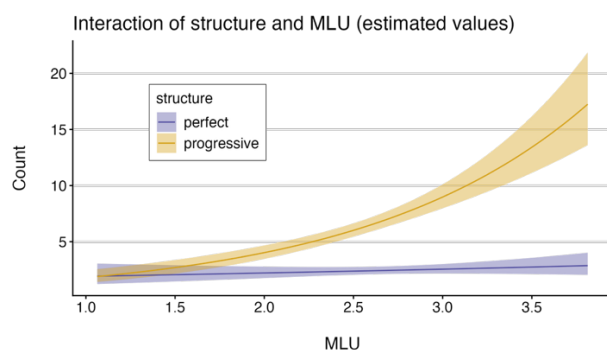


Fig 3. *Progressive utterance counts increase more than perfect as MLU increases*



Selected References and Related Works.

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